Khyatee Kanchan, who has credits like *Zubaan* and *Maidaan* under her belt. The film has "everything to do with the smallest of details", she says. Kanchan would often go with her team to local houses to seek props to place in Chandan and Shoaib's houses. "Neeraj gets the best out of people. There are no airs or hierarchy, everybody is allowed to put forward their ideas and opinions," she says. "It's literally a collaborative process."

On set, Ghaywan's deployment of a personal protocol called 'Code 360' became much-spoken about among cast and crew. In a film with a host of troubling, gut-wrenching scenes that expose how normalised and pervasive caste and religious prejudice is, it did wonders for the actors to nail their emotional cadences. It entailed the clapboard being soft, movement among crew being minimal and silence a requisite. All climax scenes were shot like this. For Shalini Vatsa, a scene-stealer as Chandan's mother Phool, it further demonstrated Ghaywan's sensitivity. "Acting [for screen] is a lot of breaks, you aren't on stage. [With Code 360] there's an understanding that the whole unit would have to go into the mood of the scene," she says. It also involved songs that Ghaywan would play on set to guide actors. Jethwa recalls Kishore Kumar's '*Raah Pe Chalte Hai*', from *Namkeen*, becoming the go-to song on their way to shoot, while Vatsa remembers two songs on Ghaywan's playlist for Phool that were favourites of hers—'*Ab Ke Baras Bhejo*' from *Bandini* and '*Yeh Jo Des Hai Mera*' from *Swades*. What also helped actors was Ghaywan's decision to shoot the film chronologically.

The experience was profound and transformative for Jethwa. "I didn't know identity was such a big issue," he says, "even though I was going through it and didn't realise it. I used to think less of myself in front of others because I couldn't speak English that well. Discrimination brings about a set of challenges the world over."

THE ROAD AHEAD

Homebound may not have created ripples at the domestic box office, collecting just about Rs 4 crore, but for Mishra, it is an artistic effort that lends itself more to "making footprints in history". The world premiere at Cannes, the second runner-up prize of International People's Choice Award at the 2025 Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF), its selection as India's official entry at the Oscars in Best International Film category are rewards in themselves. "The difference with the film," says Vatsa, "is that the appreciation is not simply 'great film and performance'. People are moved by it." *Homebound*, says Mishra, has broken even and there's hopefully more to come from releases in international territories like France.

But he is candid about the film's Oscar prospects in what's a fiercely contested Best International Film category. The last time India made it to the top five was with *Lagaan* (2001). This year's competition includes Jafar Panhi's Palme d'Or winner *It Was Just An Accident* (France), Joachim Trier's *Sentimental Value* (Norway), Park Chan Wook's *Decision to Leave* (South Korea) and Kaouther Ben Hania's *The Voice of Hind Rajab* (Tunisia), which are pretty much seen as dead locks. The more achievable target, says Mishra, is to make it to the shortlist—the top 15—with a little bit of help from Scorsese's EP status, screenings and Q&As scheduled in New York and Los Angeles, which will help strike a chord with Oscar voters. And Ghaywan's rallying call for empathy is much-needed in these increasingly divisive times. He says, "Even if there are people you disagree with, who don't look like you, talk like you, whose ideology may differ from you.... Maybe we are pointing too many daggers. Let's have a conversation and hear the other side too." ■



Actor Janhvi Kapoor and Neeraj Ghaywan

"*Homebound* represents many people of India who are often overlooked by traditional media as well as cinema"

NEERAJ GHAYWAN
Co-writer and director